The Night Josh Tillman Came to Our Apartment

A Companion Guide

Father John Misty (Josh Tillman)

Song, track 4 of I Love You, Honeybear (Sub Pop / Bella Union, 2015)

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Spoiler note: spoiler tiers do not meaningfully apply to a three-and-a-half-minute song, so this guide discusses everything. The song contains explicit lyrics; those lines are paraphrased rather than quoted here.

Quick Take

This is three and a half minutes of gorgeous-sounding character assassination, and the person being assassinated turns out to be the guy singing. Track 4 of I Love You, Honeybear, the 2015 album Josh Tillman wrote about falling in love with his wife Emma, this song is the album's cynical counterweight: a portrait of a hollow Los Angeles hookup, based on real events, in which the narrator itemizes a woman's every annoying tic and then reveals himself to be far worse than anything on the list. Tillman put it bluntly to Q magazine: "The a--hole in that song is me." The album around it was one of 2015's consensus critical triumphs (87 on Metacritic, Best New Music from Pitchfork, top-12 on four major year-end lists), and this track was routinely singled out as its bitterest, funniest, and most divisive moment. If you want the purest example of the Father John Misty trick, sincerity smuggled inside cruelty, wrapped in sweet Laurel Canyon strings, this is the song.

About the Artist: Josh Tillman, and the Other Guy

You cannot understand the song's title without the backstory, because the joke is that Father John Misty is singing about a character named Josh Tillman, who is also the real person behind Father John Misty.

Tillman spent roughly 2003 to 2010 releasing somber folk records under the name J. Tillman, a period he later described as chasing an unattainable tortured-artist archetype. As he told Loud And Quiet, "the disparity between me and him was becoming untenable." He then drummed for Fleet Foxes from 2008 to 2012, by his own account a reluctant interlude in someone else's band. After quitting, he left Seattle for Los Angeles, and during a psychedelic experience in Big Sur he climbed a tree and, in his telling, came down as Father John Misty, a name he chose precisely because it means nothing and amused him. The persona debuted on 2012's Fear Fun.

I Love You, Honeybear is the second Misty album and the one where the ironic persona collided head-on with something sincere: meeting the photographer and filmmaker Emma Elizabeth Tillman. "There was another album, but I met this person and it just made all of that irrelevant," he told Grantland's Steven Hyden. Emma's advice shaped the record's sound: "You just can't be afraid to let these songs be beautiful." Tillman described the album as an attempt to write about falling hopelessly in love "with none of the trappings" of love songs, an "experiment in hysterical transparency." To Loud And Quiet he was plainer: "I just wanted to write about love without bullshitting."

That is the frame this song sits inside. On an album that is mostly the love story, track 4 is the before picture: the narcissist Emma's arrival made obsolete.

The Story Behind the Song

Per Songfacts, the song is based on a true story, an encounter Tillman had in Los Angeles. The lyric reads at first like pure attack: a woman comes over, talks endlessly about herself, helps herself to his drugs, and gets shredded line by line for it. But Tillman has been unusually direct about who the song is really aimed at.

> *"The a--hole in that song is me... I left that experience feeling like a f--king worthless human being. It's a destructive song and it's definitely one that I will not perform after this album cycle."*
>
> *Josh Tillman to Q magazine, 2015 (via Songfacts)*

In other interview material compiled by Songfacts, he called the song a "bait and switch": it presents as criticism of the woman and reveals itself as "a portrait of wounded narcissism," his own. That reading matches how most sympathetic critics eventually heard it, and it is the reading his own music video would later make literal (more on that below).

The pledge to retire the song from live performance is part of its lore, an artist publicly deprecating one of his own most-loved songs on moral grounds. Whether he kept that promise is covered in the trivia section, and the answer is fun.

Themes and What Makes It Work

The craft here is in how precisely the cruelty is engineered to boomerang.

Start with the title. Naming the character Josh Tillman, third person, creates a hall of mirrors: the persona (Father John Misty) narrates a night in the life of the man (Josh Tillman), which lets Tillman indict himself while appearing to indict someone else. It is one of the clearest early examples of the persona games that would define his career.

Then the malapropisms. The song's most-quoted line has the woman declaring that, like, literally, music is the air she breathes; later she insists she sounds literally like Sarah Vaughan. The narrator seethes at her misuse of "literally," her "soulful affectation," her monologues explaining the cosmos, her raiding of his drug stash. The catalog of verbal tics is the satirical engine, and it is genuinely funny. But notice what the narrator is doing: keeping an itemized ledger of a stranger's flaws while she is in his apartment. The cataloguing itself is petty and insufferable, and that is the point.

The hinge comes late in the lyric, in an explicit passage where the narrator admits he went through with the encounter anyway, contempt and all. Analysts consistently identify this as the moment the indictment flips: whatever her sins of vocabulary, his sin of participation is worse. This is the switch in Tillman's "bait and switch." He is not a bystander to the vapid evening; he is its co-author, and unlike her, he knew better.

Stereogum captured the tightrope act well, calling the track a "petty, scathing laundry list of a lover's flaws" that "starts out amusing" but "becomes almost uncomfortably mean-spirited," illustrating "the thinness of the line between narcissism and self-loathing," since Tillman exhibits the very behaviors he critiques.

Within the album's arc, the song functions as structural counterpoint. I Love You, Honeybear is a concept record about courtship and marriage, and it needs this track the way a redemption story needs the unredeemed version of its hero. Critics repeatedly framed it as the album's

bitterest and funniest song, the dark foil that makes the sincerity of everything around it feel earned instead of saccharine. A decade later, Dork's anniversary essay would frame the whole album as the definitive 2010s document of love in the age of irony, and this track is the irony pole of that argument.

The Sound

The album was recorded intermittently across 2013 and 2014 in Echo Park, Los Angeles, co-produced by Tillman and Jonathan Wilson (continuing the partnership from Fear Fun at Wilson's Fivestar Studios), mixed by Phil Ek, and mastered by Greg Calbi at Sterling Sound.

On this track, the production joke is that it sounds sweet. It is a deceptively pretty, lounge-leaning soft-rock ballad: strings swell, a xylophone tinkles (Collapse Board's description), and Atwood Magazine said the instrumentals are so unassuming they resemble "an overture to a sunny Saturday morning bike ride." Some listeners hear a Beach Boys-like pop sheen. Setting acid lyrics inside a warm orchestrated Laurel Canyon bed is the album's signature move, and this track is its purest example: the prettier the arrangement, the more the venom stings.

What the Critics Say

The album's numbers first: 87 out of 100 on Metacritic from 34 reviews, one of the best-reviewed records of 2015. Pitchfork's Mike Powell gave it Best New Music, calling it "passionate and disillusioned, tender and angry, so cynical it's repulsive and so openhearted it hurts." Year-end placements included number 5 at The A.V. Club, number 9 at Billboard, number 12 at Pitchfork, and number 2 at Rough Trade.

The song itself is where the critical consensus splits, and the split is the interesting part. Sympathetic critics read it as deliberate double-edged satire, per the Stereogum reading above. Hostile critics read it as misogyny with an alibi. Collapse Board's line-by-line takedown of the album is the sharpest version of the charge:

> *"Father John Misty is a hypocrite: a megalomaniac disgusted by self-centredness in the opposite sex."*
>
> *Collapse Board, line-by-line album analysis*

INDY Week framed the open question of the whole era: whether the Misty persona is "outright misogyny or part of a larger, complex joke." Tillman's responses came in layers. He owned the a--holery outright in the Q quote. He pledged to retire the song. He made a video whose entire concept is that he is the one being satirized. During the Honeybear press cycle he largely stopped doing print interviews, saying he had been misquoted (a line about combating "the liberal mentality" was reported as "the female mentality"). And in 2017, talking to NME about a later lyric on Pure Comedy, he summarized his standing posture toward the outrage cycle: "I knew that line would sink the whole album, that people would get mad and call me a misogynist, because right below pornography, our second favourite form of entertainment is

outrage." (That quote is about a Pure Comedy line, not this song, but it is the clearest statement of his position on the charge that began with Honeybear-era tracks like this one.)

The Music Video: Tillman Seduces Tillman

The official video, posted September 18, 2015, was directed by Drew Pearce, better known as a screenwriter on Iron Man 3 and Mission: Impossible - Rogue Nation. The concept: Tillman picks himself up at a bar, takes himself home, and hooks up with himself, via a body double named Tyler, before slipping out the next morning. Tillman thanked Tyler in the announcement, noting the two kissed "no fewer than two dozen times."

He also claimed the video was "partially inspired by the LeBron James quote, 'It is precisely the superficial differences between people who are otherwise alike that inform the hostilities between them.'" LeBron James said no such thing; the deadpan fake attribution is classic Misty press-release trolling.

The video settles the interpretive question about the song more decisively than any interview: the person the narrator is disgusted by, and drawn to, and abandons, is himself. Pearce described the video as an exploration of narcissism and self-obsession. Watch it at youtube.com/watch?v=flIIeW7e1xA.

What You Might Not Know

- The retirement pledge did not stick. Tillman vowed in 2015 never to play the song after the Honeybear cycle because it was "destructive." Setlist.fm logs 229 performances, roughly 15th most-played in his catalog, with the most recent logged performance on October 2, 2024 at the Masonic Lodge at Hollywood Forever in Los Angeles, nearly a decade after the pledge. Apparently the song forgave him, or he forgave it.
- Nearly the whole album out-performs it live, which says more about the album than the song: the title track has 639 logged plays (his most-performed song ever), Chateau Lobby #4 has 585, Holy Shit 462, The Ideal Husband 314.
- The two best official live documents of this track are an NPR Live Sessions video (livesessions.npr.org) and an officially released live version recorded at Ancienne Belgique in Brussels on November 10, 2015.
- The defining TV moment of the album era was not this song: on November 3, 2014, Tillman announced the album on Letterman by debuting Bored in the USA with a 22-piece orchestra, starting at the piano, sitting cross-legged on it, then dropping to his knees while the studio audience laughed. IMPOSE Magazine wrote an entire essay (Misty-Schmisty) treating the performance as a case study in whether satire on late-night TV can still function as critique.
- The best audio primer on the Josh Tillman versus Father John Misty split, exactly the tension this song is titled around, is his long WTF with Marc Maron conversation (episode 457, December 2013), recorded while he was making the album.

- The album got a remastered 10th-anniversary edition from Sub Pop on February 14, 2025. Valentine's Day, on brand.
- The song has quietly avoided the meme economy: no notable covers, no film or TV sync placements, and a surprisingly thin indexed Reddit trail. Its reputation is a connoisseur's favorite, frequently cited in track-by-track album writing as a highlight (Atwood Magazine called it a page "ripped straight from Misty's diary") but without the crossover life of Real Love Baby or the TV infamy of Bored in the USA.

If You Liked This

Critics ground Father John Misty's savage-satirical mode in a specific lineage (AllMusic's bio names solo-era John Lennon, Scott Walker, Randy Newman, Harry Nilsson, and Dory Previn). Best starting points:

- Leonard Cohen, "Chelsea Hotel #2": the closest single-song ancestor, a cruel-then-self-implicating memoir of a hookup that turns the knife on its own narrator.
- Randy Newman, Sail Away era ("God's Song," "Sail Away"): the master of the unreliable narrator delivered with a straight face over pretty piano.
- Harry Nilsson, Nilsson Schmilsson ("You're Breakin' My Heart"): gorgeous melody carrying vicious wit, the exact production-versus-lyric contrast this song runs on.
- Warren Zevon, "Desperados Under the Eaves": Los Angeles misanthropy set to lush piano-pop.
- Pulp, "I Spy" or "Common People": Jarvis Cocker working the same contemptuous-narrator-at-a-party mode from the Britpop side.

Within the Father John Misty catalog, go next to:

- "The Ideal Husband" (same album): the confessional rage-purge counterpart, the panic attack to this song's smirk.
- "I Love You, Honeybear" and "Chateau Lobby #4 (in C for Two Virgins)": the sincere flipside, the love story this song exists to offset.
- "Bored in the USA": the satirist-at-the-piano showpiece, plus the legendary Letterman performance.
- "Mr. Tillman" (2018): the closest conceptual sequel, another song where Josh Tillman appears as a third-person character, this time seen through the eyes of an exasperated hotel clerk.
- Pure Comedy (2017), especially the title track and "Leaving LA": the fully zoomed-out version of the misanthropy, aimed at the species instead of one apartment.

Companion media worth the time: the WTF with Marc Maron episode (457), the Grantland profile "The Third Revelation of Father John Misty," the Rolling Stone pieces from the era (including the notorious Taylor Swift-on-LSD interview), and the Drew Pearce video.

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